Key question
Why did a Palestinian uprising break out in the occupied territories in 1987?

Key date
Palestinian *Intifada*: 1987–93

Key term
Intifada
The Palestinian uprising that erupted in Gaza and the West Bank in 1987.

3 | The Palestinian *Intifada* 1987–93

On 8 December 1987 an Israeli army vehicle in Gaza crashed into a lorry, killing four of the Palestinians on board. Rumours spread that it had been a deliberate act of revenge for the killing of an Israeli two days before. The funerals of the Palestinians became huge demonstrations. At one of them a youth was shot dead by an Israeli soldier. As tension mounted, thousands of Palestinians took to the streets, both in Gaza and on the West Bank, and put up barricades of tyres and corrugated iron. From behind them, they stoned Israeli army patrols. The crash that killed four Palestinians sparked off the ***Intifada***, or uprising. What were the roots of this uprising?

Life in the occupied territories

Since the Six-Day War of 1967, thousands of Israeli troops had been stationed in Gaza and the West Bank. For many Israelis, the West Bank was vital to Israel's security; it protected the country's narrow waist (it is only 24 km from the Mediterranean to the West Bank). If Israel held on to these lands, they would be finishing off the job they had started in 1948–9 by securing control of the rest of Palestine.

In the end, Israel never actually annexed Gaza and the West Bank. The two areas never became part of the state of Israel with all the inhabitants becoming Israeli citizens. Instead, they became known as the 'occupied territories' and the occupying force was the Israeli army. Military rule was imposed. Resistance was dealt with harshly and was interpreted in many ways: holding a rally or demonstration, organising a strike or just waving the Palestinian flag. Israeli troops rounded up PLO suspects and others whom they saw as a threat to their security. Thousands were jailed without trial, some tortured and hundreds were deported (usually to Jordan). Sometimes their houses were blown up, leaving their families homeless.

The Israeli army also confiscated land and declared it to be Jewish property. This was sometimes done for security reasons, to keep an eye on the Palestinians. However, much of this land was allocated for the building of Jewish settlements and thousands of Jewish civilians were given financial incentives to move to these settlements. The Israeli military authorities also built roads, to link the towns and settlements, and established military camps and checkpoints. The movement of Palestinians was closely monitored and they were regularly stopped at road blocks.

There was another reason for building Jewish settlements: for many Israelis, the West Bank is known as Judea and Samaria, part of the ancient land of Israel, the land that God had promised to the Israelites. Many of the Jewish settlers were determined to colonise this land so that it could never be given back to the Palestinians. It was part of Eretz Israel, the Israel of the Bible.

It became a common sight for the Palestinians to see Jewish settlements being built on land they considered to be theirs. By 1987, there were over 80,000 Israelis living in settlements in and